



WEEK SEVEN · MODULE THREE

The Mock Interview

Twenty-five questions, three reference calls, and a camera you will not enjoy

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This module is uncomfortable, and it is supposed to be. It is far better to be uncomfortable here than in a drawing room in Belgravia.

Do not read the debrief until you have written all twenty-five answers. If you read ahead, you will have learned nothing and you will not know it.

The camera exercise is the one people skip. It is the one that changes the most.

CHAPTER I

How this week is practised

*Five exercises***LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

Understand the sequence.

Exercise	What it trains, and how long
1 · The CV, rebuilt	Honesty and restraint. Two hours, and you will delete more than you write.
2 · The reference calls	Three real calls, this week, before you need them. Thirty minutes, and it is the exercise with the highest return of the whole programme.
3 · Twenty-five questions	The interview itself. Two hours, written, then aloud.
4 · The camera	What you actually look like. Twenty minutes, and it is the one you will want to skip.
5 · The offer	Reading a contract, and negotiating once, calmly.

CHAPTER II

Exercise one

The CV, rebuilt from nothing

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Produce a two-page CV that would survive a reference check and eight seconds.

From nothing. Not editing the old one, because editing preserves the inflation, and you will not see it, because you wrote it and it feels true.

Blank page. The structure from Module 1. Two pages. Then apply the eleven tests, honestly, one by one.

Test	Pass or fail
Adjectives about myself	Zero. Count them. Then delete them, and see what is left, and whether it is evidence.
Duties written as scope	Every line quantified: household size, staff, residences, budget, travel.
Any family named or hinted at	If yes, this is not a stylistic error. It is a disqualification, and I will send it back.
Gaps	Each one explained in a single line. Not defended. Explained.
Short tenures	If there is a pattern, it is addressed in the letter, in one sentence, without defensiveness.
Two pages	Two. If you cannot, you have written duties.
Typographical errors	Read it backwards, sentence by sentence. This is a profession whose entire product is that you notice things.

CHAPTER III

Exercise two

*The reference calls***LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

Secure and brief three referees, this week, before you need them.

This is the exercise people put off, and it is the one that will most change what happens to you this year.

Call three people. Not email. Call. And ask them plainly:

THE QUESTION

"I am beginning to look for a role in private service. Would you be comfortable being a reference for me, and would you be comfortable being asked whether you would have me back?"

Then listen. Not to the answer. To the half second before it.

Write down, for each: what they said, how fast they said it, and what they emphasised. A referee who hesitates is a referee you have just saved yourself from, and finding that out now, in July, is worth a very great deal.

Then brief the three who did not hesitate: what you are looking for, what will be asked, and two or three specific things you did that they may have forgotten. People forget. A vague reference is a poor one, even when it is warm.

CHAPTER IV

Exercise three

*The mock interview***LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

Answer twenty-five questions, in writing, then aloud, before reading the debrief.

Write every answer. Then say it aloud, timed. Then read the debrief, and not before.

The opening

1. Tell me about yourself.
2. Why private service?
3. Why this role, and why now?

The history

4. Walk me through your last role.
5. Why did you leave?
6. There is a gap here of seven months. What were you doing?
7. You have had three roles in four years. Should I be concerned?
8. What was the hardest thing you dealt with there?
9. Tell me about a mistake you made.

The craft

10. What does discretion mean to you?
11. The principal's wife asks you what time her husband got home last night. You know. What do you say?
12. A journalist telephones the house and says he already has the story. What do you do?
13. You realise a supplier has overcharged us by two thousand euros and nobody has noticed. Walk me through the next hour.

14. It is Thursday. The flight is cancelled and the board meeting is at nine in Geneva. Talk me through it.
15. How would you describe the difference between good service and exceptional service?
16. A member of staff who has been here eleven years does something you believe is wrong. What do you do?

The pressure

17. How do you handle pressure?
18. What would you do if I asked you to do something you thought was a mistake?
19. What would you do if I asked you to do something you thought was wrong?
20. What is your greatest weakness?

The traps

21. Who were you with before? We probably know them.
22. Go on. What are they really like?
23. That must have been difficult, working for someone like that.
24. What are you looking for, in terms of salary?

The end

25. Do you have any questions for us?

CHAPTER V

The debrief

The eleven that decide it

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Compare your answers to the standard.

1 · "Tell me about yourself."

Ninety seconds. Where you are from professionally, what you have done, what rung you are on, and why you are in this room. Then **stop**. They are timing you and they will not tell you so. Six minutes of excellent material is a worse answer than ninety seconds of adequate material, and the reason is in the case of the five minutes.

5 · "Why did you leave?"

Neutral, brief, no wound. "The family relocated." "The role changed." "It came to a natural end and we parted well." There is no version of the honest, aggrieved answer that helps you, including the one where you were entirely right. They are not learning about that family. They are learning what you will say about them.

7 · "Three roles in four years. Should I be concerned?"

Answer it head on, without defensiveness, in two sentences, and then stop. "Two were seasonal by design and the third relocated. I am looking for a house to stay in, and I would want you to know that before you took me." Do not explain for a paragraph. Length here is read as anxiety, and anxiety is read as a reason to worry.

8 · "The hardest thing you dealt with."

The most dangerous good question in the set, and the one that catches the most people, because they want to answer it well. Give the **shape** of the problem and the **method** of the solution, and no identifying detail whatever. Not the city, not the season, not the number of children, not the industry. Then reread your written answer, and find the two details you did not notice you left in. There are always two.

9 · "Tell me about a mistake."

Give a real one. Small, real, owned, and with what you changed afterwards. The candidate who cannot produce a mistake is telling you that she will conceal them, and every experienced interviewer knows it, and it is a worse answer than any mistake you could confess.

11 · The wife asks what time he got home.

"I am not sure of the exact time." Nothing else. No elaboration, no expression, no looking away. Week 4, Scenario 11. You do not carry information between principals, in either direction, ever, and you will feel dishonest, and you are being a professional.

19 · "Something you thought was a mistake."

You say so, once, in private, briefly, with the reason and an alternative. And then, if they still want it, you do it, well, and without sulking, and you never mention it again. That is the answer, and the second half is the half they are listening for.

20 · "Something you thought was wrong."

Different question entirely, and they know it, and they are watching to see whether you noticed the difference. You decline. Calmly, without a lecture, without moral theatre, and you accept the consequence. Your Week 3 code of conduct named three things you would refuse at the cost of the position. Name one of them, plainly, and stop talking.

22 to 24 · The traps

All three are the same test wearing different clothes. "I am not able to talk about the families I have worked for. I am sure you would want the same, in time." Warm. Complete. No apology. And if they push, the same words, the same face, and no smile that suggests you might yield.

25 · "Your salary expectation."

Your band, in one sentence, without apologising, and then hand it back. "For a role at this level, in this city, I would expect between X and Y. But I would rather understand the role properly first." Then stop talking. The next person to speak has conceded.

26 · "Do you have any questions?"

Three, written in the notebook you brought, and all three about the work. What does this role find difficult. How is the staff structured. What would a good first ninety days look like to you. Nothing about the travel, nothing about the life, nothing about them.

CHAPTER

Exercise four

The camera

Film yourself answering five of the twenty-five. Any five, including at least one of the traps.

Then watch it **with the sound off**, and answer one question only:

THE ONLY QUESTION

Does that person look comfortable, or does she look like she wants something?

You will know within four seconds, and you will not enjoy it, and it is the single most useful four seconds in this programme.

Then watch it again with the sound on, and count: the filled silences, the nervous laugh, the sentence that went on after it had finished. Write the number down. Film it again on Sunday, and write the number down again.

CHAPTER VI

Exercise five

*The offer***LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

Read an offer properly, and negotiate once.

THE OFFER, AS RECEIVED

Private concierge to a family of four. Geneva, with travel. Ninety-five thousand francs.

Live-out. Flexible hours. Two days off per week. Six-month probation. Start in three weeks.

They would like an answer by Friday.

Write three things.

- The seven questions you must have answered in writing before you accept. Module 1, Chapter IX.
- The two or three points you will negotiate, with a reason for each. Not five. Two or three, and each one must be substantive rather than a test of your own courage.
- Your written reply. Under a hundred and fifty words. Calm, specific, unapologetic, and containing the sentence that lets them say no without either of you losing anything.

And then answer this, honestly, in one paragraph: **what would make you walk away from this offer?** If your answer is "nothing", you are not negotiating. You are hoping, and they will feel it in the first line.

CHAPTER VII

Marking scheme

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Know how this is assessed.

Criterion	What earns it
The CV	Zero adjectives. Every line scope, not duties. No family named or hinted at. Two pages.
The reference calls	Made. Actually made, by telephone, this week. I will ask you what each of them said in the half second before they answered.
The traps	Questions 22, 23 and 24 answered identically, warmly, and without apology. A candidate who softens on the third has failed the module.
Question 20	The difference between a mistake and a wrong. If your answer to 19 and 20 is the same, you have not read Week 3.
The camera	Filmed twice, and the count written down both times.
The offer	Two or three points, substantive, with reasons. And an honest answer to what would make you walk away.

HOW TO SUBMIT, AND HOW TO BOOK YOUR SESSION

- 1. Submit.** Everything you produced this week goes into the **Submit** area of **Module 4**, inside your student portal. One PDF. Not by email, and not in the chat.
- 2. Book.** The moment your work is uploaded, a **Book your session** button appears in that same place. Click it and choose your slot with me. Do it straight away, while you are there, because the slots for each week are limited and they are taken in the order they are booked.
- 3. Leave me time.** Book your session for at least **two days after your submission**, so that I can read your work properly beforehand. That way the session is spent on the correction rather than on the reading, and you get every minute of it.

The work from this module is submitted together with your deliverable, in a single PDF.

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